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HOME, I'M DARLING



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Characters

JUDY, 38

JOHNNY, 37

FRAN, 35

MARCUS, 43

SYLVIA, 67

ALEX, 30

ACT ONE

SCENE 1

A 1950s suburban semi: an Ideal Home, immaculately clean. Kitchen, hallway and living room downstairs, bedroom upstairs. The kitchen has classic English Rose units, formica-topped table, lino floor and a large fridge which hums continually.

Early morning on a beautiful spring day. JUDY bustles in the kitchen, putting final touches to the breakfast table (toast in a rack, teapot, butter dish, a boiled egg in an egg cup).

Upstairs, JOHNNY knots his tie in the bedroom mirror.

JUDY goes to the bottom of the stairs.

JUDY: Johnny!

JUDY goes back into the kitchen, then to the bottom of the stairs again.

I'm taking the top off your egg!

JUDY goes back into the kitchen, slices the top off the boiled egg and looks inside.

JOHNNY comes into the kitchen. JUDY kisses him and adjusts his tie.

Have you seen this beautiful day?

JOHNNY: Heavenly.

JUDY: 'Morning, darling.

JOHNNY: 'Morning.

JOHNNY sits down at the table, looking at his egg.

Look at that – perfect.

JUDY butters toast for both of them. JOHNNY settles to eating his breakfast.

JUDY: You'll enjoy your drive to the office, this lovely sunshine.

JOHNNY: Delicious.

JUDY: You are funny, it's only toast.

JOHNNY: You make the best toast, it's perfect. You could get a job at the Ritz just doing the toast in the morning.

JUDY: Then I couldn't cook your breakfast.

JOHNNY: No, you're right. Don't do it, I need you here.

JUDY looks around the room, takes a breath, satisfied.

JUDY: What about a chicken?

JOHNNY: What about a chicken?

JUDY: I grow most of our vegetables, what about a chicken too, for your morning egg? Pottering about, scratching.

JOHNNY: A sheep grazing the lawn, save me getting the mower out.

JUDY: I don't see why not. A goat, maybe.

JOHNNY: And a cow living in the pantry.

JUDY: Milk on tap.

JOHNNY: The smallest farm in the world, in Welwyn Garden City.

JUDY: One chicken.

JOHNNY: Your Sweet Peas. Pecked to bits.

JUDY: Hmm. Yes. Also the pantry's quite small.

JOHNNY: It's the perfect size for the two of us.

JUDY: Not so good for livestock. No, silly idea, forget it.

JOHNNY: You're always thinking of improvements. I'm a lucky man.

JUDY: Yes you are.

JOHNNY: Particularly when you wake me up the way you did this morning.

JUDY giggles.

JUDY: I don't know what you're talking about. Tea?

JUDY pours the tea.

JOHNNY: Are you happy, darling?

JUDY: Terribly. Aren't you?

JOHNNY: Oh yes, appallingly.

JUDY: Appallingly? I like appallingly.

JOHNNY: It's disgraceful. Shouldn't be allowed.

I keep thinking we'll get a letter. 'Happiness hasn't come off the ration, you know.'

JUDY: A letter from

JOHNNY: The police? Something about public decency.

JUDY: Like a stiff letter from the bank.

JOHNNY: 'It has come to our attention, Mr Martin, that you and Mrs Martin are Offensively Happy. We ask that you desist at once. This uxoriousness is quite unacceptable.'

JUDY: Ux

JOHNNY: Uxoriousness. It means a surfeit of spousal affection. It isn't at all the done thing for a man to be so keen on his own wife.

JUDY: Then you're an uxor.

JOHNNY: No, I think uxor is wife.

JUDY: Is it?

JOHNNY: I think so. Latin.

JUDY: I'm sure you're right.

JOHNNY: So you're the uxor that I'm all uxorious about.

JUDY laughs.

JUDY: You're cheerful.

JOHNNY: It popped into my head, as I was lying in the bath you ran for me, that I will have nothing to do at the weekend.

JUDY: Nothing to do?

JOHNNY: To the house. No tiling or plastering, no dust sheets. Nothing left.

JUDY: You've done a wonderful job.

JOHNNY: You as well. In your dungarees, scarf round your head like Rosie the Riveter.

JUDY: Will you know what to do with yourself?

JOHNNY: I expect we'll find something.

JUDY: We could go dancing?

JOHNNY: Yes, perhaps.

JUDY: Whatever you want to do, darling.

JOHNNY: Sickeningly happy.

Is there a newspaper?

JUDY: Yes, sorry.

JUDY goes out to the hallway and picks up the newspaper from the doormat.

JOHNNY: Do you know, I'm so contented I'm not sure I even care if the promotion doesn't come off.

JUDY: Oh?

JOHNNY: I look around and think well, what more do I need? My wife, my beautiful finished house. The money would

come in handy, but we don't *need* it, do we? We've got everything.

JUDY: No of course.

JOHNNY: Asking for more might be greedy. Knowing I'm utterly content with what I've got.

JUDY: Yes no that's wonderful, darling.

Is it today?

JOHNNY: Is what?

JUDY: Will you find out today?

JOHNNY: I don't know. Soon, I think. Now, marmalade or lemon curd?

JUDY: It's wonderful you're feeling so philosophical about it.

Have some marmalade, it's a new batch.

Only don't let it hold you back from making every effort. You've been there the longest, by rights they should have made you Assistant Manager some time ago, it's only fair.

JOHNNY: You always defend me.

JUDY: Of course I do I'm your wife.

You deserve that job. Don't miss out by being diffident.

Or late.

JOHNNY: No, alright.

JOHNNY stands up, draining his tea cup.

Delicious breakfast, thank you.

He goes to the hallway and puts on his hat and coat. JUDY picks up his lunch box and follows him.

JUDY: I'm so proud of you.

She hands him his lunch box and his briefcase. He kisses her.

Have a good day, darling.

JOHNNY: Same to you. Don't buy any chickens.

JUDY: I promise. Goodbye.

JOHNNY goes out of the front door with his briefcase and lunch box. JUDY waves and smiles from the door as he goes down the path.

JUDY comes back to the kitchen, goes to a drawer and takes out a laptop computer.

She brings it back to the kitchen table, opens it and sits down.

SCENE 2

Afternoon, the same day. JUDY and FRAN are in the kitchen.

JUDY is decanting some modern groceries into 1950s tins and boxes and putting them away.

FRAN sits with a cup of tea. There are a number of vintage dresses slung over the back of one of the dining chairs.

JUDY: Johnny?

FRAN: Yes.

JUDY: My Johnny?

FRAN: I was surprised because you don't go in the shopping centre.

JUDY: We didn't agree with them building it.

FRAN: That's what I thought.

JUDY: And we loved the old cereal factory, we were heartbroken they knocked it down.

FRAN: It was derelict by then, wasn't it? Probably a hazard.

JUDY: They could have propped it up, the what d'you call it, the front of it

FRAN: The façade.

JUDY: Façade, exactly. That was everyone's horizon, that was the face of our town since the twenties.

I don't expect it registers as a protest, just the two of us boycotting, but still.

Pass the Self-Raising, will you?

FRAN does.

He takes his lunch with him, he doesn't go out for pizza.

FRAN: It looked exactly like him.

JUDY: You were in there?

FRAN: Going past the window. I was going to wave, but it was too far.

JUDY: Did you see who

FRAN: No, I didn't recognise

JUDY: It probably wasn't him.

FRAN: I recognised his suit.

I don't know who she was.

JUDY: Probably someone from the office.

FRAN: Dark hair.

JUDY: Right.

FRAN: You know them all from the office, do you?

JUDY: Yes, I've met them.

FRAN: They all get on, do they?

JUDY: Yes he gets on with all of them apart from one of them.

FRAN: Quite young. Well, younger than

JUDY: Younger than me?

FRAN: I um. I was at a distance so I don't know, really.

JUDY: Getting harder to find proper washing powder, all those awful capsules.

FRAN: I'm sure there's a perfectly

JUDY: Yes, I'm sure there is.

FRAN: Sure there's nothing to worry about.

JUDY: I'm not worried – you seem more worried than I am.

FRAN: Just you never really know what someone gets up to when you're not there, do you, or how they are with other people

JUDY: Johnny doesn't get up to anything, god he wouldn't know where to start.

Where's the sugar gone?

FRAN passes the sugar to JUDY.

FRAN: Marcus wants me to quit work, do this.

JUDY: This is work.

FRAN: Quit my job, I mean.

JUDY: He doesn't want you to stop and have babies, does he?

FRAN: Oh god no.

JUDY: OK, good.

FRAN: Yuck.

JUDY: No, I know.

FRAN: He just means running our home, like you do.

JUDY: It is nice. It makes sense for us.

FRAN: You still like it?

JUDY: I do. I like the calm. Looking around and knowing everything's in order. Having time to clean behind things,

it's a deep, quiet kind of happy. Our home. All ready for him. I pop upstairs just before Johnny gets back, pin my hair, little bit of perfume. Take my pinny off. Daisy-fresh.

Then he walks in the door and

JUDY smiles to herself.

Yeah.

What are you thinking? Is it something you'd

FRAN: Oh, Marcus is making so much noise about it I can't hear what I think.

When he gets an idea in his head I mean I love how tenacious he is about things but when he goes on and on.

Does Johnny drive you mad sometimes? Properly mad?

JUDY: He doesn't really.

FRAN: No.

I just don't think I've got a domestic goddess in me. I leave things on the stairs intending to take them up and then I find I've been quite happily walking past them for weeks. I come home after a twelve hour day and I'm frazzled. Longest recipe I used this week was 'Pierce Film Lid'.

JUDY: But if you were at home, you'd have time to

FRAN: This is what I'm saying – even if I had the time, I'm just not sure I would. It's always going to be a problem. We both like things tidy, it's just his tidy is a lot tidier than mine.

JUDY: You do need a consensus.

FRAN: I always think that when they cite 'unreasonable behaviour' in divorce cases. For some people that's leaving a towel on the floor, unreasonable behaviour. Others wouldn't mind if you shagged a different lover every lunchtime as long as the washing's hung up.

JUDY: Sorry, I've just got to pop upstairs – one moment.

FRAN: Sure.

JUDY goes upstairs. She loudly closes the bathroom door then tiptoes into the bedroom and closes the door softly.

FRAN looks through the pile of dresses.

JUDY picks up the phone beside the bed and dials.

She sits down while it rings, stands as it's answered, then realises it's gone to voicemail.

JUDY: Hi Johnny, it's me.

Hope you're having a good day, I um

You're probably at a valuation.

Sorry, it's nothing really

Don't worry about phoning back, I'll see you when you get home

Just wanted to say hello, really, so

Hello.

OK, I'll see you later, bye-bye

Um, it's nothing to worry about, everything's fine.

JUDY replaces the phone. She quietly comes out of the bedroom, goes into the bathroom and flushes the loo, then comes downstairs to the kitchen. FRAN is holding one of the dresses.

FRAN: What are you doing with these?

JUDY: Having a clearout. eBay.

FRAN: This one? Not this one.

JUDY: I never wear it.

FRAN: But it's beautiful, look at it.

JUDY: I've got so many, I can't close the wardrobe. Pops open all the time, all these big skirts trying to escape.

FRAN: Is this *(she checks the label)* yes, it is. That'll go.

JUDY: They're all original.

FRAN: Of course: I've never seen you in repro, darling.

Ooh, this one's handmade. Look at the love that's gone into that, nobody sews like that now. The detail round the

JUDY: I know, it's gorgeous.

FRAN: It's gorgeous, how can you bear it?

Can I buy this from you?

JUDY: You?

FRAN: Yeah. No?

JUDY: I don't know, I hadn't thought of

FRAN: Proper price, not mates' rates.

JUDY: Thing is, if you had it and Johnny saw you in it

FRAN: Was it a present from Johnny?

JUDY: I can't remember.

FRAN: OK.

Sorry, I shouldn't have asked.

JUDY: No it's fine.

FRAN: Put a pile of dresses in front of a stylist, I can't help having a rummage. Magpie behaviour, it's awful.

JUDY: I don't want him to know I'm selling them. That's all it is.

FRAN: Because?

JUDY: Just the housing market's not so good. And that's our favourite bit of the day, when he comes home from work. Mix him a drink, take his shoes off, give him his slippers,

help him relax. I'm not going to stand there and say 'by the way darling we're running out of money'.

We're not running out of money. We just need to be a bit careful.

FRAN: Well and going two salaries down to one

JUDY: I used to earn more than him.

FRAN: Did you? Sorry, I shouldn't be surprised. Only you hear the stuff about men being paid more just for having a penis.

JUDY: I've got a degree, so

FRAN: Johnny didn't go to university?

JUDY: Don't tell him I told you, he's a bit funny about it.

FRAN: Oh, men.

JUDY: And nobody needs as many vintage dresses as I've got.

FRAN: Well good luck with the eBay.

FRAN sits down.

Sorry I said penis.

JUDY: Fran, look – the Johnny thing

FRAN: I'm sorry, I didn't mean to suggest

JUDY: I don't want to hear anything like that, I don't want it in the house.

FRAN: OK, sorry.

Sorry.

FRAN drinks her tea, looks around.

How d'you get your taps so shiny?

JUDY: Um, half a lemon. Rubbed round.

FRAN: Huh.

JUDY: Old ways are the best.

FRAN: Marcus says that.

JUDY: It's all there on the internet, all the hints and tips. You can do most things with lemon juice, vinegar, soda crystals. Better than all the chemicals people use now.

FRAN: I don't know anything about

JUDY: There's a book if you're interested.

FRAN: Yeah?

JUDY goes to a drawer, pulls out a book and hands it to FRAN.

JUDY: It's my bible, this.

FRAN: "How To Ruin Your Home Without Help"

JUDY: *Run.* How to run your home.

FRAN: Sorry, it's very small writing.

JUDY: 1949, so it's a bit early. Middle-class women doing without servants for the first time, after the war.

FRAN: Wow, this is

Terrifying.

JUDY: No, she splits it all down into daily tasks, weekly things,

Every room gets a light going-over every morning, air the bedrooms, make the bed, then each afternoon you do one or two rooms properly – behind things and under things, vacuum, dust, wipe, polish. Then dinner cooking. Plus Monday is your washing day and Friday is baking.

FRAN: So much to do.

JUDY: It's manageable when you break it down. Plus we're not dealing with all that coal dust anymore.

FRAN: You've been talking to me for an hour, you should have been ironing the door handles. I should go. You really do all this?

JUDY: Have a borrow if you like.

FRAN: Can I? Thank you.

FRAN gets up to leave. JUDY picks up the dress they were looking at and holds it up.

JUDY: Maybe not this one, it's a good dancing dress I'll need it next month, won't I? Kicks out really nicely when you spin.

FRAN: Need it for?

JUDY: Jivestock?

FRAN: Yes.

JUDY: You haven't forgotten?

FRAN: No no.

JUDY: 28th to the 30th.

FRAN: Yes no absolutely. No, very excited.

JUDY puts the dress back on the pile. They walk to the front door.

I'm sorry I upset you

JUDY: I'm not upset.

FRAN picks up some letters from the mat.

FRAN: Post for you.

JUDY: Can you believe how late they come now? Four o'clock, look.

FRAN: See you next week?

JUDY: Yes, and you're coming for tea on Sunday, yes?

FRAN: Yes of course. 'Bye.

JUDY: Bye bye.

JUDY closes the door and comes back down the hallway looking through the pile of letters. She sees one that looks serious and opens it, standing by the kitchen table. She reads it, putting a hand to her mouth.

The doorbell rings, making JUDY jump. She stuffs the letter back in its envelope then opens the cupboard under the sink and puts the letter right at the back.

JUDY goes down the hallway and opens the front door. There's nobody there, but she calls to a figure retreating down the path.

JUDY: Hello?

SYLVIA: Oh hi.

Didn't think you were in.

JUDY: No, I had to wash my hands I was just

SYLVIA: Hello darling.

SYLVIA has reached the front door and she and JUDY hug hello.

How are you?

JUDY: Yeah I'm fine

Come in.

JUDY leads SYLVIA through to the kitchen.

SYLVIA: I didn't think you were in I thought you were out.

JUDY: No, well I'm in.

SYLVIA: I thought maybe you'd started a new job.

JUDY: No.

SYLVIA: I was just going to get a pen and paper from the car. Can't text you, can I?

JUDY: Is that why you didn't tell me you were coming? Because I haven't got a mobile phone?

SYLVIA: I didn't know I was coming today but yes, I do think it's bloody-minded of you when the entire rest of the world has accepted a basic level of

JUDY: Tea?

SYLVIA: Yes please.

Anyway I was just in the area, thought I'd pop in.

JUDY goes to put the kettle on. SYLVIA takes off her coat to reveal a colourful dress underneath.

JUDY: We do have a landline. Why were you in the area?

SYLVIA: I've been to a funeral, actually.

JUDY looks at SYLVIA's clothing.

It said 'no black'.

JUDY: Who, um

Is it sugar at the moment or not sugar?

SYLVIA: Have you got any herbal?

JUDY: No.

SYLVIA: It was Erica.

JUDY: Erica from Willowfield?

SYLVIA: Yes.

JUDY: But she wasn't

SYLVIA: No, my age. Cancer.

JUDY: God.

SYLVIA: Coming for all of us, isn't it?

JUDY: Was that a yes to sugar?

SYLVIA: Yeah, just one.

JUDY puts the sugar bowl onto the tea tray. SYLVIA sits down.

SYLVIA: I know you never cared much for her, for Erica.

JUDY: It was the way she talked to me, like she was my mother.

SYLVIA: We were all the parents, that was the point.

JUDY: I'm sorry she's passed on.

SYLVIA: Lot of love for her at the service. All the people she'd rescued over the years, all standing up to say something.

JUDY: I remember her banana bread.

SYLVIA: Yes. God. They didn't mention that.

JUDY: Everything we ate there was brown.

SYLVIA: We were healthy.

JUDY: I used to dream about oven chips.

SYLVIA: You'll learn when you have kids they're never happy, whatever you do.

JUDY pours water into the teapot.

Look at your fridge.

JUDY: You've seen it before.

SYLVIA: Can't believe it's still going.

JUDY: Off and on. More off than on recently.

SYLVIA: Chuck it, get a new one.

JUDY: I like this one. We went all the way to Sunderland for it.

SYLVIA: But it doesn't work.

JUDY: Yes but you don't just give up on things.

SYLVIA: You do if they don't work.

JUDY: You try and mend it. Or get someone to

SYLVIA: How about get a modern fridge and just hide it inside that one?

JUDY: Yeah that's really not the point.

SYLVIA: You've got a laptop, haven't you?

JUDY: Mum.

SYLVIA: Sorry.

JUDY: We don't want to keep buying new things all the time.

SYLVIA: Alright, sorry.

Maya's pregnant.

JUDY: Maya?

SYLVIA: Anita's daughter? She's in a sustainable community near Worcester now, says she couldn't imagine living with just her own family. And Anita's still working, she's running a women's refuge in Nottingham.

JUDY: Good for her.

SYLVIA: Some of the stories: god, the funding squeeze. Makes Thatcher look bountiful. I'm thinking I might give them some of the money.

JUDY puts the everyday cake tin onto the tea tray and picks it up.

Proper cups and saucers.

JUDY: Shall we sit in the living room?

SYLVIA: Not that these things should depend on donations.

SYLVIA follows JUDY into the living room, looking around her as she goes.

JUDY: What money?

SYLVIA: What?

JUDY: 'Some of the money'?

SYLVIA: Erica left me some money. Quite a lot, in fact.

JUDY: I thought she didn't have any.

SYLVIA: You remember we rented Willowfield off her grisly old aunt?

JUDY: Yes

SYLVIA: Well the aunt left her the whole estate a few years ago, and property around Brighton's gone through the roof so Erica sold it for an absolute bomb, the barns and orchard and everything.

JUDY: Milk?

SYLVIA: Just a little.

JUDY hands SYLVIA a cup and saucer.

Can't believe she's gone. I can't think of anyone less likely to die.

JUDY: She was a good person.

Cake?

SYLVIA: Ooh no, I mustn't.

JUDY: I made it.

SYLVIA looks into the cake tin.

SYLVIA: Gosh, that looks sinful.

JUDY: Only if you ate all of it.

SYLVIA: Go on then, I'll have a little slice.

JUDY holds the knife on top of the cake.

JUDY: There?

SYLVIA: Ooh no, smaller, smaller.

JUDY moves the knife, cuts a sliver. JUDY hands the cake to SYLVIA on a plate.

SYLVIA: Jacqui was there – remember her son David?

JUDY: Grubby little boy. Used to eat woodlice.

SYLVIA: Lawyer now, apparently.

JUDY: Gone to the dark side.

SYLVIA: Human rights lawyer.

JUDY: Right.

SYLVIA: Anyway darling how are you? How are you and Johnny?

JUDY: Yes no we're fine.

SYLVIA: You're still enjoying it, being at home?

JUDY: Yes I like it, it suits me.

SYLVIA: It's all perfectly rosy, you couldn't be happier?

JUDY: Why d'you ask?

SYLVIA: People were asking after you today, I realised I didn't know really. How you are.

JUDY: No, we're well. Johnny's being promoted soon,

SYLVIA: Wonderful.

JUDY: Once that happens we'll have a bit more money.

SYLVIA: So money's tight?

JUDY: No, Mum. We've got to be careful with it, but that's OK. That's what we love about the fifties: it's not all about acquiring *stuff*. I like being frugal, it's a project, it's fun.

SYLVIA: So when it stops being fun you'll get a job?

JUDY: I've got a job, this is my job.

SYLVIA: But if you can't really afford it, comfortably. You've done your experiment, there'd be no shame in putting yourself back out in the

JUDY: Oh you'd love that, wouldn't you?

SYLVIA: What?

JUDY: For this to fail.

SYLVIA: I've made no secret of the fact I'd like to see you doing something more fulfilling.

JUDY: Maybe a human rights lawyer.

SYLVIA: Darling I'm sorry but what do you think it's like for me, standing there at Erica's funeral, the woman who put the staunch into feminist, people asking me how you are, what you're doing, and having to tell them you're a *housewife?* My daughter.

All those years, all those pamphlets, marches. Ghastly rides to London in a minibus, hoping you'd get it by osmosis at least.

JUDY: I'm a feminist.

SYLVIA: Ha.

JUDY: I am. I get to choose now. This is what I've chosen.

SYLVIA: "This is what a feminist looks like"? Wearing a frilly apron and dancing around with a duster isn't feminism.

I don't know why you ever let Johnny coax you into it.

JUDY: There wasn't any coaxing, it was a mutual

SYLVIA: It might feel like that, but if you look back long enough this was a man's idea first.

JUDY: I'm thirty-eight years old, I'm

SYLVIA: Completely dependent. You've given up your car.

JUDY: We don't need two cars if I'm not going to the office, that's just wasteful.

I spent years with that firm. I know what they were charging me out at, and it was a heck of a lot more than I was taking home.

SYLVIA: If you don't like the way something is, you stay in the ring and fight it.

JUDY: Why do I need a job to be fulfilled? Bit capitalist, isn't it? I'm surprised you've swallowed that.

SYLVIA: You've made a luxury choice, don't pretend it's political. You've got no children to support, a husband who's healthy and working

JUDY: I'm working. My work here is work, why isn't this valued?

SYLVIA: Because men don't do it.

What would you do if something happened between you?

JUDY: Nothing's happened, what d'you mean?

SYLVIA: How would you survive if Johnny came home tonight and said he wanted a divorce?

JUDY: What a horrible thing to say, why would you say that?

SYLVIA: It's all very well for him, out in the world all day long doing whatever he likes and you're stuck here going crackers.

JUDY: I'm not remotely going crackers I'm very happy.

And you going out to work didn't stop you and Dad getting divorced, did it?

Mum?

SYLVIA: Alright darling, I'm sorry.

I'm very sorry.

JUDY: Let's leave it, shall we?

They sit for a moment, SYLVIA thinking.

SYLVIA: Can I ask you something darling?

JUDY: What?

SYLVIA: What do you *do*? What do you do all day?

SCENE 3

Evening, the same day. JOHNNY is in the living room reading the newspaper, a drink beside him.

Several pans are bubbling on the stove.

JUDY sits at the kitchen table, still, looking at JOHNNY's lunchbox on the table in front of her. After some time she pulls off the lid. She takes an untouched, greaseproof-paper-wrapped sandwich out of the box.

She lays the table for dinner. She moves the lunchbox onto the counter by the sink. She holds the sandwiches over the bin, then changes her mind and puts them into the fridge.

JUDY: Dinner, Johnny.

JOHNNY puts down his newspaper and comes into the kitchen.

JOHNNY: That. Smells. Amazing.

JOHNNY kisses JUDY on the shoulder as she serves lamb chops onto two plates.

JUDY: You must be hungry.

JOHNNY: Starving.

JOHNNY sits down at the table.

You didn't ask her to stay for dinner, then?

JUDY: I didn't think it'd be relaxing for you, to get back and find my mother on the sofa, saying things.

JOHNNY: No well, thank you.

JUDY sets his plate down in front of him and sits down with her own.

Thank you.

JUDY: There's plenty more mash if you want seconds. Actually, here, you should have some of this.

JUDY scrapes one of her chops onto JOHNNY's plate.

JOHNNY: What're you

JUDY: Don't want you going without.

JOHNNY: I'd say I'm doing pretty well looking at this. Is everything alright?

JUDY: How was day?

JOHNNY: Alright. Bit more news about the job.

JUDY: Yes?

JOHNNY: Well, bit more and a bit less. Alex says the decision's not going to be made for a few weeks, there's going to be a 'listening exercise'.

JUDY: Goodness.

JOHNNY: Might be some kind of restructure.

JUDY: So there might not be an assistant manager?

JOHNNY: Don't know, I mean I don't think it'll be just one boss and everyone else is a minion. But means it'll be a while before we know. While all this listening and observing goes on.

JUDY: Making a bit of a meal of it if you ask me.

JOHNNY: Well you know, new boss. Have to make your presence felt, don't you? But now Toby's looking like he wants to be considered too.

JUDY: You've been there much longer than him.

JOHNNY: I think it's going to go on who's best at bringing vendors in, my love. Toby's numbers are really good.

How was your day, anyway, apart from Sylvia's visitation?

JUDY: Oh, fine. Normal. Nothing much.

JOHNNY: Toby was hilarious this morning.

JUDY: Yes?

JOHNNY: Monday morning meeting so everyone's you know, *bleurgh*, he's spouting off about his weekend cooking adventures – what he's sourced from the farmers' market,

JUDY: Sourced?

JOHNNY: Yeah *sourced*, he never says bought. Weird stuff the butcher keeps back for him

JUDY: Kangaroo burgers.

JOHNNY: This new Japanese beef – have you heard about this, most expensive beef in the world apparently it's got this marbled texture

JUDY: I bet it has by the time it's come from Japan.

JOHNNY: *Wagyu*, that's it. Apparently Mrs Toby was furious when she found out how much it cost but then when he cooked it for her she pretty much, you know

JUDY: Probably just the surprise at being cooked for.

JOHNNY: He does all the food in their house. Doesn't let her anywhere near the kitchen, he says.

JUDY: I'm sure he lets her clean up.

JOHNNY: Yeah, Janet said that. So then the conversation gets onto baking, and Sean has the idea we should have a bake off at the office,

JUDY: What's that?

JOHNNY: Where everyone brings in a cake they've made, like a competition?

They've all been watching that programme, the people baking?

JUDY: Oh, the baking programme.

JOHNNY: They're all really into it.

JUDY: They don't bake, they watch baking.

JOHNNY: Anyway so that's happening on Friday, we're having a bake off. For *team-building.*

JUDY: I can bake a cake for you to take in, what kind would you like?

JOHNNY: I think I'm supposed to make it myself.

JUDY: You?

JOHNNY: I could probably manage a cake, couldn't I? I mean how difficult

JUDY: Why don't I just do it? Make sure you win.

JOHNNY: They'll know you've made it, won't they? It'll be obvious. Mine'll be all

JUDY: Lopsided

JOHNNY: Probably. I'd still like to try. Do you mind?

JUDY: Tell me what sort you want to do and I'll get the ingredients in. I'll get extra in case you need a couple of goes.

JOHNNY: I was a better cook than you before we started this arrangement.

JUDY: Only 'cause I'd never had a chance to practise.

JOHNNY: And I'd looked after myself for years before that.

JUDY: This *arrangement?*

JOHNNY: What?

JUDY: You called it an *arrangement*, makes it sound like a

JOHNNY: I don't know, what do we call it?

JUDY: I think we call it a marriage, Johnny.

JOHNNY: OK, but we were married for quite a long time before you started doing all the cooking.

Don't be upset. I didn't think this would be upsetting, it's just a cake.

JUDY: I'm not, I'm not upset.

JOHNNY: You know I love it, I'm not saying I don't love it, what we do.

They eat in silence for a moment.

This is really delicious.

JUDY: There's more potatoes.

JUDY gets up, serves him some more potatoes.

JOHNNY: Thank you. Whoa whoa that's plenty, thank you.

JUDY: Well you must be hungry. Not having any lunch.

JOHNNY: Not having

JUDY: Your sandwiches.

JOHNNY: Right.

JUDY: D'you not like my piccalilli anymore?

JOHNNY: I love it.

JUDY: I'm very happy to change the sandwich. I make it like that cause it's your favourite, but you've only got to say.

JOHNNY: I'm sorry. If I'm trying to do four valuations in a day and the morning ones take longer it's just not enough time to get back to the office, so if I've left my lunchbox in the fridge

JUDY: You've never brought them home before.

JOHNNY: No well I usually have them later probably, afternoon tea sort of

JUDY: And you get something else at lunchtime.

JOHNNY: Sometimes I have to grab a sandwich from the garage, it's really only happened a couple of

JUDY: As long as it is a sandwich, not something bigger like a pizza at the new shopping centre.

JOHNNY: What?

JUDY: Fran says she saw you in Pizza Pronto.

JOHNNY: When?

JUDY: What d'you mean, *when*? I told her it couldn't have been you, what d'you mean 'when'?

JOHNNY: I've been a couple of times. The crowd from the office, someone's birthday or

JUDY: We promised we'd never go in the new centre.

JOHNNY: If everyone else wants to go it's quite hard to – you don't have this, being at home.

The Pizza Pronto has a door from the car park you don't actually have to go in or look in any of the shops, you know, I've never bought anything. So I sort of convinced myself it didn't count. I didn't inhale.

I mean we could go there if you

I like pizza, we never have pizza.

JUDY: Well it's not very fifties, is it? They didn't have pizza then.

JOHNNY: They did in Italy.

JUDY: Fran saw you today.

JOHNNY: OK.

JUDY: And she didn't seem to think it was any kind of big work group, she said you were there with a woman, just you.

JOHNNY: Right. And do you want to know who that was?

JUDY: Yes.

JOHNNY: That was Alex.

JUDY: Alex.

JOHNNY: My new boss?

JUDY: Alex your boss is a *woman*?

JOHNNY: Yes they do let women be bosses now.

JUDY: I thought it was a man.

JOHNNY: I've never said it was a man.

JUDY: You never said it wasn't a man.

JOHNNY: I didn't think I needed to.

JUDY: And you were having lunch with her.

JOHNNY: She's taken everyone out to lunch this week, one at a time – get to know us individually, she says, part of the listening exercise.

On the company card, so it didn't cost us anything.

Alright?

JUDY: Yes, I

I'm so sorry.

JUDY laughs.

I'm sorry.

JOHNNY: You didn't really think I'd

JUDY: Oh god.

Sorry, I'm. I'm a bit crying because I'm relieved.

JOHNNY: What did you imagine?

JUDY: Oh don't, it's so silly.

JOHNNY: D'you think that's where I take my dates? Pizza Pronto in the mall where everyone could see me?

JUDY: Don't, I'm embarrassed.

JOHNNY: I'd be much more secretive.

JUDY: Well I hope you wouldn't

JOHNNY: Of course I wouldn't.

Alright now?

JUDY: I might have that back, actually.

JUDY takes back the chop she'd scraped onto JOHNNY's plate.

JOHNNY: Is this why I had that rather enigmatic voicemail from you earlier?

JUDY: Fran was here this afternoon. I basically told her to go away and not bring me any more stories.

JOHNNY: Quite right. Does she want you running to her with tales about what Marcus gets up to?

JUDY: So silly, I just *assumed* this Alex was

JOHNNY: Very much not a man.

JUDY: Right.

What's she like?

JOHNNY: Alex?

JUDY: Yes is she nice?

JOHNNY: She's – yeah, she's nice.

JUDY: You haven't said anything about her.

JOHNNY: No, I like her. I mean, you know, she's the *boss* but she's a laugh as well. She makes me laugh, anyway.

JUDY: What sort of

JOHNNY: What?

JUDY: What does she do to make you laugh?

JOHNNY: Oh I don't know, just

Things she says. I can't think of

JUDY: D'you want to have her over?

JOHNNY: Here?

JUDY: Yes, that's what people do, isn't it? Have the new boss over? I could make cocktails.

SCENE 4

Evening. ALEX (30) sits on the sofa, sipping a cocktail. JOHNNY stands. JUDY perches on the arm rest at the other end of the sofa. She's wearing a cocktail dress with a full skirt and a small fur around her shoulders. ALEX is wearing a trouser suit – work clothes – and JOHNNY still has his suit trousers on, but has swapped his shirt for a more casual one.

ALEX: It's a what?

JOHNNY: Gimlet.

JUDY: Gin and lime syrup.

ALEX: Wow, it's quite

JOHNNY: D'you want something a bit

ALEX: No no it's delicious, just don't let me have another one or I won't be able to drive back to the

JOHNNY: You've got to go back have you?

ALEX: Well fingers crossed, if Toby gets this

JOHNNY: *(To JUDY.)* Toby's got a big valuation going through this evening.

ALEX: Big buy-to-let vendor with four properties she's looking to offload all at once, and probably more business later on. Toby's over there now convincing her to list with us and not the other two agencies she's met with.

JUDY: Right, important.

ALEX: If he gets her signed by midnight, that's made our target for the month, my first month. I'm hoping we can head

back to the office, get the paperwork done and then all be in the pub celebrating by last orders.

Obviously you're welcome to come if

JOHNNY: Cool, thanks.

ALEX: Both of you, obviously.

JUDY: Tonight?

ALEX: They've set the bar quite high to see if I'm up to it. So if we smash it, that's awesome. We might get Office of the Month.

JOHNNY: Pizza vouchers!

ALEX: *(re the drink.)* Ooh, that's lovely isn't it? Cheers.

JUDY: Back in a sec.

JUDY goes out to the kitchen. She opens the oven, checks inside it, then closes it again.

ALEX: Your house is incredible.

JOHNNY: I did say it's very fifties.

ALEX: No, it's amazing.

JUDY takes out a couple of serving dishes and puts them on the table. There's a bunch of flowers which she picks up, unsure where to move them to. She puts them in the sink.

JUDY takes a plate of Ritz crackers spread with cream cheese and olives out of the fridge.

D'you do this a lot, having people round for cocktails?

JOHNNY: Um, no. I'd go as far as to say you're the first.

ALEX: I'm honoured. I feel quite underdressed.

JOHNNY: No, you look great.

I mean that's just Judy, she likes to, you know

ALEX: Should we give her a hand in there?

JOHNNY: Oh um, no I think she's

I'll go and see.

JOHNNY goes to the kitchen. ALEX takes her phone out of her handbag and checks it.

JUDY: I feel completely overdressed.

JOHNNY: No, you look

JUDY: She's so young.

JOHNNY: I don't think she's quite as young as she looks.

JUDY: Right.

JOHNNY: Have we got any nibbles? Some Kettle Crisps or

JUDY: I'm doing it now, Johnny.

I had to put the cheese straws back in 'cause she was late.

JOHNNY: You could take the fur off.

JUDY: You do think I'm overdressed.

JOHNNY: Just want you to feel comfortable.

JUDY: I did feel comfortable, now I feel silly.

JUDY goes to the fridge, takes out an elaborately-arranged crudites plate with a bowl of dip at the centre, and another plate of devilled eggs with piped centres.

JOHNNY: Don't worry about it, it's just casual drinks.

JUDY sets the two plates down on the table.

It's just casual.

JUDY: Go in there and talk to her.

JOHNNY retreats to the living room.

JUDY looks at her reflection in the window above the sink, tries to loosen the back of her hair a little. She takes off her earrings and necklace, and the fur.

JOHNNY: She's just bringing some, um

ALEX: Sorry I was just

JOHNNY: Some nibbles.

ALEX: Just seeing if there's any word from Toby.

JOHNNY: No no, go ahead.

JUDY takes the cheese straws out of the oven and slides them onto the serving plate.

ALEX: I made him promise to call me as soon as he knows.

JUDY picks up the serving plate, and the crudites dish and carries them into the living room.

JUDY: Here we are.

JOHNNY: Lovely.

JUDY: Help yourself, Alex.

ALEX: Thank you.

JUDY goes back to the kitchen, picks up the other two plates and brings them through.

(To JOHNNY) She's amazing.

Wow, look at this.

JOHNNY: What's this one?

JUDY: Devilled eggs, you've had them before.

ALEX: Oh, you've taken your earrings off, I was just admiring them.

JUDY: Felt a bit overdressed.

ALEX: No, I was just saying to Johnny how scruffy I felt.

JOHNNY: I said it's just casual, so

ALEX: I've been admiring your house, Judy. I feel like I'm in Mad Men or something.

JUDY: We did it all ourselves, didn't we?

ALEX: Be an interesting one to try selling. What would we say?

JOHNNY: 'Character features.' 'Charming retro fittings.'

ALEX: Yes, 'lovingly personalised by current owners.'

JUDY: 'Quirky'?

ALEX: No, quirky means avocado bathroom.

You haven't

JOHNNY: No, pink.

ALEX: I mean the awful thing is you probably would end up ripping it all out, going back to neutral when you come to selling it.

JOHNNY: "It's maybe not everyone's taste....."

ALEX: Oh god, Church Street.

ALEX and JOHNNY laugh.

JUDY: What's this?

JOHNNY: I told you about it. Church Street, the one with the

JOHNNY laughs again.

JUDY: If it's that funny I think I'd remember.

JOHNNY: OK, so he's a geologist, lots of photos of rocks all over the house, including this huge print as you walk into the living room of some kind of underground rock formation, like wavy layers of stalactite

ALEX: Massive close up, I mean it's all you can look at, and it looks like – what did he say it's called?

JOHNNY: Cave Bacon.

ALEX: Yes. Only it turns out cave bacon looks a lot less like bacon than it does a

ALEX and JOHNNY collapse laughing.

Than a

JUDY: What?

ALEX: No, you say.

JOHNNY: Basically this picture looks like a massive vulva.

ALEX: Hanging there over the mantelpiece, you can't take your eyes off it.

JOHNNY: And the guy says,

ALEX: Quite innocently.

JOHNNY: "Is there anything I need to do to the place before having buyers round?"

ALEX: I nearly lost it.

JOHNNY: Wasn't it your first

ALEX: First day in the branch, yeah. Poor Johnny trying to make a good impression, taking me out to a valuation.

JOHNNY: I'm in this man's living room, trying to work out a polite way to suggest he takes the enormous vadge off the wall. My new boss standing there.

ALEX: Ahh. I actually thought "this job's going to be alright, you know?" This guy's alright.

JOHNNY: That's nice.

ALEX: So yeah, buyers don't like personality.

JUDY: I don't think we'd want to move, after all the work we've put in.

ALEX: No, sure. It's amazing.

JUDY: There's nothing in this room that's not original. Actually I made the curtains but it was vintage material.

ALEX: Johnny said you used to work in finance.

JUDY: Yes.

ALEX: I did finance at university.

JUDY: Which one?

ALEX: LSE.

JOHNNY: London.

ALEX: Where were you?

JUDY: Birmingham. Uni, Birmingham uni.

ALEX: Was it fun?

JUDY: Where I met Johnny. Not at the university, we met at a vintage car thing.

JOHNNY: Johnny No-Degree over here.

ALEX: Yeah, but it's not your fault you had glandular fever when you did your A Levels, is it?

The phone beeps again. ALEX looks down at her bag.

JUDY: Do check that if you need to.

ALEX: Oh, thanks, d'you mind?

ALEX takes the phone out and opens a text message. She jumps up, triumphant.

Yes! Yes, we got it! She's signed.

She goes to JOHNNY, hugs him.

Hurray hurray

JOHNNY: Yay

They jump up and down slightly, a little awkward, before ALEX moves back and sits.

ALEX: Good work Toby.

JOHNNY: Devilled egg to celebrate?

JOHNNY picks up the plate and holds it towards ALEX.

ALEX: Yeah, thank you.

ALEX takes one, then places it carefully on the table while she replies to TOBY's text.

JUDY: Look at you, helping.

ALEX: Sorry, just letting Toby know I got his text.

There we go. Gosh, phew.

ALEX sits back with her drink, looks around.

So with the fifties thing

JUDY: Yes?

ALEX: Do you go to normal shops and stuff, I mean the normal supermarket or

JUDY: You can't really not go shopping.

JOHNNY: She puts everything in old packets when she gets home.

JUDY: We don't have anything that's not fifties or earlier. The furniture, the fridge,

ALEX: I've heard about the fridge.

JUDY: Sixty years that's been working. Modern appliances you'd never get

ALEX: Washing machine?

JUDY: They had washing machines thankfully, yeah.

ALEX: And they had a telly.

JUDY: Some people, yeah.

ALEX: *(Pointing at the TV.)* But that – that doesn't show fifties programmes.

JUDY: Johnny adapted it inside, it plays DVDs.

ALEX: Brilliant, that's so clever.

JUDY: When I was little we watched old films on a Saturday afternoon – me and my dad. Completely fell in love with the fifties – the houses, the clothes, the hair. James Stewart. Doris Day. James Stewart *and* Doris Day. I just had this very strong affinity. Doris Day and Rock Hudson.

JOHNNY: Gay, of course.

JUDY: Yes but I didn't know that.

ALEX: Cinema?

JUDY: Sometimes, if they're showing something we – don't really get much you'd want to see, do you, at the cinema here?

ALEX: I love it, going to the cinema.

JOHNNY: Oh yeah. I mean I often think it's something we should do more.

JUDY: Everything now, it's all just aimed at teenagers.

JOHNNY: Of course the teenager was a fifties' invention.

JUDY: Car crashes and explosions.

JOHNNY: I mean for big films, you've got to watch them on a big screen, really, haven't you?

ALEX: Big action films, yeah.

JOHNNY: Really get it right up in your face, really immersive. Mind you the TVs some people have in their houses now, almost as big as a cinema screen aren't they? No I do think we should go a bit more often.

JUDY: Do you?

JOHNNY: Maybe try and get into a bit more modern films,

JUDY: You're being very talkative, Johnny.

JOHNNY: I'm just saying maybe we could broaden our horizons a bit.

JUDY: Sit down, Johnny, you're *looming.*

JOHNNY: OK, sorry.

JUDY: I'm so sorry, he gets a bit

ALEX: No no I'm used to it.

JOHNNY sits down.

JUDY: Cheese straw?

ALEX: Um, thanks I'm still working on this, um

Egg.

ALEX picks up her devilled egg from the table.

And Johnny was saying the other day it's not just the aesthetic side, it's about the culture, fifties' values.

JUDY: Did he? I mean yes, we do I suppose. People were kinder, I think. People took the time. It wasn't just everyone staring at their own smartphone, not seeing anyone else. Too busy taking photos of their dinner to really enjoy it. I don't get it.

ALEX: You didn't photograph Johnny's bake off entry, then?

JOHNNY: Should have done. For comedy.

ALEX: It wasn't that bad, it tasted nice. Just not quite the showstopper.

(To JUDY.) Sean made this ring-shaped thing with coconut icing.

JUDY: Like a Bundt cake?

ALEX: I've no idea what it's called.

JOHNNY: He'd done piping and everything. And it was moist.

Toby was so cross.

ALEX: You were a strong contender. Just not quite top dog.

JOHNNY: Should have got the wife to make it. Trying to play fair.

JUDY: Fifties values.

I mean I do think back then there was more community, people were nicer to each other.

ALEX: Unless you were gay or

JUDY: Sorry?

ALEX: I don't think it was very easy in the fifties if you were black or gay.

JOHNNY: Or disabled or

ALEX: No, exactly.

JUDY: Well obviously it wasn't perfect.

ALEX: If you were ill, if you got ill now, would you use modern medicine or only things they had in the fifties?

JUDY: I think we'd just go to the hospital, it's not like a religious cult.

ALEX: No, sorry, just trying to work out the rules. You don't use the internet or

JOHNNY: We've got a laptop.

ALEX: Have you?

JUDY: I mean now, you can't really

JOHNNY: Living in the modern world.

ALEX: Yes I suppose I thought you were really trying not to live in the

JOHNNY: We don't have hard and fast rules about things, we just

JUDY: We need the internet for buying things, vintage things on eBay,

And meet ups, car meetings, festivals.

There's a festival we go to called Jivestock. Big country estate in Wiltshire, a whole weekend of music and dancing and classes, workshops. Everyone's dressed like us and you forget about the modern world, you can't even see it.

ALEX: And it's all arranged on the internet.

JOHNNY: Modern communities, isn't it, communities have all moved online now. Everyone sharing information about their weird little hobby

ALEX: Yes, how did people find each other before?

JOHNNY: But no, I guess it might seem a bit inconsistent. All this and then a laptop hidden in the cupboard.

JUDY: But it doesn't matter, does it? It's not a test.

ALEX looks at her phone.

ALEX: OK, Toby needs me, I'd better head, you know?

I'm so sorry.

JOHNNY: No it's fine.

ALEX: Sorry I feel like I just got here. It's so lovely to meet you.

JUDY: Yes you too.

ALEX: I've promised to buy a round so if you guys did feel like coming to join us

JUDY: Probably a bit late for us.

ALEX: OK, no problem. I can see myself

JOHNNY: No no I'll see you out.

ALEX: Gentleman. Very fifties.

JUDY: 'Bye then.

JOHNNY walks ALEX out to the hallway, finds her coat on the hat stand and helps her into it.

JUDY stays still in the living room.

ALEX: We'll be in the Bell if you change your minds about coming out.

JOHNNY: I think Judy wants to stay um

ALEX: See you tomorrow, then.

JOHNNY: Bright and early.

ALEX: Ha, depends if we get a lock-in. Bye.

JOHNNY: Home safe.

JOHNNY closes the front door behind ALEX. He starts back towards the living room.

JUDY picks up her and ALEX's cocktail glasses. She takes them through to the kitchen and puts them in the sink.

JOHNNY picks up a couple of the snack plates and carries them into the kitchen.

JOHNNY: D'you think we maybe slightly over-catered?

JUDY: It'll all go back in the fridge.

JOHNNY: Yes, picnic tomorrow.

JUDY picks up some plates. She goes to the kitchen, puts the plates down on the table.

JUDY: You seem to get on very well with her.

JOHNNY: Got to make an effort, haven't you?

JUDY comes back into the living room, picks up the other plates.

Put those down.

JUDY: What?

JOHNNY: Just put those down a second, come over here.

JUDY puts the plates down and goes to sit on the sofa with JOHNNY. JOHNNY touches her hair.

JOHNNY: Can this come down a bit?

JUDY takes some pins out of the back of her hair.

JOHNNY puts a hand in the back of JUDY's hair and pulls her towards him for a kiss. She responds, leaning into him.

He tries to manoeuvre her into a lying-down position, running a hand up her leg under her skirt. JUDY laughs.

JUDY: Wait, let me just

Let me just clear up then we can go to bed.

JOHNNY: Leave it, come on.

JOHNNY succeeds in lying her down, it becomes clear he intends them to fuck on the sofa.

JUDY: Wait, Johnny, wait

Let's just

Johnny

JOHNNY: What?

JUDY: Just

Not here, I

JOHNNY: What's the matter?

JUDY: I don't want to do it on the sofa.

JOHNNY: I thought you liked it when I took charge.

JUDY gets up, smooths down her dress. She picks up the plates and goes into the kitchen.

JUDY: Just don't feel like it, sorry.

JOHNNY puts his head in his hands, then looks around the room. After a few moments, he gets up and goes to the hallway. He picks up his coat and goes into the kitchen.

JOHNNY: I'm going to the Bell.

JUDY: Johnny

JOHNNY: All of them down there *bonding* and I'm not there, what's that look like? When she's deciding who to give the job to.

JUDY: But that's why we invited her, get her on her own.

JOHNNY: I'll see you later, OK?

JOHNNY goes down the hall. He puts out a hand to take his hat then decides against it. He goes out of the front door and closes it behind him.

JUDY: Johnny?

JUDY looks around her, putting a hand to her mouth.

SCENE 5

Sunday afternoon.

JUDY, JOHNNY, FRAN and FRAN's husband MARCUS are sitting in the living room with cups of tea and cake plates. On the coffee table, the remains of a plain-looking loaf cake.

FRAN: I never met anyone who grew up in a commune before, how come I didn't know this about you?

JUDY: I don't know, it wasn't really *me*, I guess.

FRAN: What was it like?

JUDY: Big run-down house out in the country near Brighton. Random collection of oddballs trying to be unconventional but constantly drawing up rotas because you have to be really organised if you're living in a group, that's the paradox of it.

They called themselves an 'intentional community'. As if everyone else lives together by accident.

FRAN: How many people?

JUDY: About fifteen adults. Tons of grubby children running around. And me, I was the only teenager.

FRAN: Was it religious?

JUDY: No no. Feminism and CND. We had communal dinner every day which was basically lentil lasagne and a lecture about patriarchy or whatever. Railing against Thatcher even though she'd gone by then.

And they rejected the idea that their self-worth was linked to how much Hoovering they did, so nobody cleaned. I said to Erica once – Erica was the leader although of course no one was the leader, except everyone knew that she was – I said to her why didn't they get a cleaner, but she said it was exploitative of other women.

So yeah, my filthy childhood.

MARCUS: And were they all shagging each other?

FRAN: Marcus.

MARCUS: Didn't you want to ask that?

JUDY: People assume it's some free love thing but they were too busy sitting in a circle analysing their *feelings*. Adults grabbing the wooden spoon off each other.

JOHNNY: Put you off people for life, didn't it?

JUDY: It did a bit, yeah. I really hated Erica. Mum thought she was Boadicea, I thought she was a battleaxe.

I desperately wanted to go and live with my dad, but he wasn't up to it.

MARCUS: Ah, you're a daddy's girl, are you?

JOHNNY: Lovely cake, Fran.

FRAN: I didn't have time to do any icing or anything.

JUDY: No, it's a tea cake, you don't need to ice it, that sort.

MARCUS: Don't want to gild the lily.

JOHNNY: Very interesting flavour.

FRAN: Lemon and rosemary. Not a fifties recipe, I'm afraid.

JOHNNY: Get it out of our house!

JUDY: Johnny. It doesn't have to be a fifties recipe.

JOHNNY: No, I'm joking. Don't think I've ever had rosemary in a cake before.

MARCUS: I don't think anyone has.

FRAN: Still it explains a lot about you, doesn't it, Judy?

JUDY: Does it?

FRAN: I mean, why you'd have chosen something much more traditional now.

MARCUS: Oh for god's sake.

FRAN: What?

MARCUS: Sorry, she does this. Fran loves a crashingly obvious diagnosis, she can't help psychologising people.

FRAN: Well it's a window to look through, isn't it? It's interesting.

JUDY: More tea?

MARCUS: Yes please.

JUDY pours MARCUS another cup.

Tea strainer.

JUDY: Yes, proper tea.

FRAN: 1953, tea bags came in.

JOHNNY: Just a preference, I think.

MARCUS: No, absolutely. Fran makes it in the mug at home and I can almost hear my mother turning in her grave.

FRAN: She can't, you cremated her.

JOHNNY puts his plate down.

JOHNNY: Really good cake.

FRAN: Thank you. I have been trying to be a bit more domestic, haven't I?

MARCUS: I haven't had to get into an unmade bed all week.

FRAN: I always make the bed, don't listen.

MARCUS: She keeps opening windows.

FRAN: It's in the book: give the rooms an airing. And I've been cooking. Picking things up off the stairs.

MARCUS: Yes, the house is transformed.

FRAN: Fuck off.

Sorry, Judy.

JUDY: What?

FRAN: You don't like swearing.

JUDY: I don't mind swearing.

FRAN: I wouldn't normally, but Marcus is being a knob this afternoon.

MARCUS: Fran thinks that having a cleaner means you don't have to clean your house the rest of the week.

FRAN: That's exactly what having a cleaner means.

MARCUS: In any case as I keep trying to explain, it's about the level of attention you can give things and there's no way, doing a job, that you could ever give the house the amount of love and attention Judy does.

FRAN: I love my job. Judy hated her job.

JUDY: I didn't hate it. No, I hated it. Offices are awful.

FRAN: I don't work in an office.

JUDY: The carpets, the lighting.

MARCUS: Yes, most people look offensively ugly under strip lights.

JUDY: Stale air. The kitchen corner with teaspoons everywhere, brown lumps in the sugar. People having birthdays all the time.

MARCUS: I mean look at this room. What is it that makes it so warm, so welcoming? We all know, don't we? I know you do, Johnny.

JOHNNY: The rug?

MARCUS: It's Judy. The Angel in the House.

JUDY: Stop it, I'm blushing.

FRAN: Yes stop it Marcus.

MARCUS: Don't be cross – you could be just as good as her if you practised. Almost as good, anyway.

FRAN: Stop it.

MARCUS: Oh my love. Was I being a bit rough?

FRAN: Yes.

MARCUS: I'm sorry, I'll play nicely. My beautiful wife. I like you best even if you are a terrible slattern.

MARCUS kisses her. She relents. JUDY and JOHNNY watch, uncomfortable.

There. Better?

FRAN: Much.

JUDY: Say about Jivestock, Johnny.

JOHNNY: Yes, so we've been looking at the brochure.

JUDY: Did you know The Lamours are playing on the Saturday?

MARCUS: No.

JOHNNY: There's four stages this year, it's getting bigger every time.

JUDY: Long as it doesn't get big like Glastonbury or something. I like that it's still our crowd. No tattooed rockabilly girls who can't even pin their hair properly. Cheap polka dot dresses.

JOHNNY: Anyway, we were getting excited

JUDY: Since it's only a month away.

JOHNNY: And thinking about how we really get our money's worth out of it, and we thought maybe try to get down there on the Thursday night, see if we can secure a better camping spot.

JUDY: There's some really good dance workshops on Friday morning.

JOHNNY: Depends of course on you guys being able to get the day off on the Friday.

JUDY: But if we go early we might be able to get in the campsite right by the lake, be really up close to everything.

MARCUS: Actually, we wanted to talk to you about this today.

Thing is, we're not going to make it to Jivestock this year.

JOHNNY: Oh.

JUDY: Why?

MARCUS: We've got an issue with that weekend, sadly. We need to get away for a proper holiday.

FRAN: We still haven't had a honeymoon.

MARCUS: There's only one window coming up where I'd be safe to leave the office, and the Jivestock weekend directly clashes.

JOHNNY: Where are you going?

MARCUS: Cuba, we think.

FRAN: Marcus wants to go to Havana, see all the old cars.

JOHNNY: No, of course, amazing.

FRAN: We're really sorry.

MARCUS: Obviously we'd love you to borrow the Airstream and

FRAN: Yes, please take the Airstream.

JUDY: I don't know if we'll go if you don't.

FRAN: Oh don't say that.

JUDY: I mean we won't know anybody without you.

JOHNNY: We'll talk about it.

FRAN: You're one of the best dancers there.

JUDY: But if Johnny doesn't dance, I won't have a partner, we normally take turns with

MARCUS: Oh, there's better partners there than me.

FRAN: I thought you were having lessons, Johnny.

JOHNNY: Yeah, there's not been much time recently, work's been really busy and

JUDY: Sorry, I'm just going to go and

Fill up the tea.

JUDY goes out to the kitchen.

FRAN: Is she

JOHNNY: Yeah yeah, she's fine, don't worry.

MARCUS: We never really said we'd go this year.

JOHNNY: No, we probably just assumed, 'cause we'd been two years running.

MARCUS: We thought maybe we could find a weekend later in the summer, all go for a caravan weekend together.

JOHNNY: Whatever, yeah, whatever you want to do.

Back in a sec.

JOHNNY goes out to the kitchen. JUDY looks at him in silent distress.

FRAN: I feel terrible.

MARCUS: They can still go, they don't need us.

FRAN: They do, though, don't they? They're shy. And you've seen Johnny dancing.

MARCUS: Don't worry about it, we've told them now, it's done.

FRAN: Don't worry about it?

JOHNNY goes to hug JUDY, but she steps back, afraid she'll cry.

JUDY: Not now.

MARCUS leans close to FRAN, speaking quietly.

MARCUS: D'you want to change our minds, forget about Cuba?

FRAN: No, of course not.

MARCUS: It was you who said we needed to get away, talk about things. Preferably somewhere incredibly expensive.

FRAN: Cuba's not

MARCUS: To stay in the places we like, yes it is.

JUDY: Go back in, I'll be there in a minute.

JOHNNY: Are you sure you

JUDY: Talk about it later, Johnny.

JOHNNY goes back into the living room.

FRAN: She OK?

JOHNNY: All fine. She'll be back in a minute.

MARCUS: How's the Austin holding up?

JOHNNY: Broke down again the other day, Wednesday.

MARCUS: Oh no.

JOHNNY: Had to pull over on the side of the A414, smoke puthering out. Thank god for Patrick.

MARCUS: Thank god for mobile phones.

JOHNNY: Got me back on the road, but I was an hour late.

MARCUS: And eye-wateringly expensive.

JOHNNY: And now he says it'll need a new clutch in the next few months, that one's not going to hold up.

JUDY goes to the larder and takes out an elaborately decorated chocolate cake on a plate. She puts it on the kitchen table and looks at it.

MARCUS: Patrick's a bit of a gem, isn't he?

JOHNNY: Godsend.

MARCUS: Bring him a 1956 Bel Air and he'll scratch his head and frown but you can tell he's just thrilled to get his hands on it.

JOHNNY: Oh, thrilled. Lucky to have him so close.

MARCUS: I don't know how you manage. I love the Chevy for weekends, but I couldn't do without the Audi for work, just need the reliability, you know?

JOHNNY: Yeah, I don't know. I like having a car I can fix myself – mostly, anyway – open the bonnet and know what everything is, it feels honest. Modern cars it's just a computer on wheels, isn't it?

JUDY comes in, carrying the cake on a plate.

What's that?

JUDY: It's a cake Johnny.

JOHNNY: I know it's a cake, why's it

JUDY: I'd completely forgotten I made a cake too.

MARCUS: Looks tremendous.

JUDY: Johnny's favourite. It's called Chocolate Chiffon Cake.

JOHNNY's phone rings in his pocket. He takes it out to look at it.

I didn't bring it out earlier because Johnny's been on at me about over-catering, but we'll never get through it by ourselves.

JOHNNY: Sorry, I've got to take this, it's work, 'scuse me.

JOHNNY goes out of the room.

(Into phone.) Hi, how are you?

JUDY: Will you have a slice, Marcus?

MARCUS: Yes please.

JOHNNY heads up the stairs.

I don't think I've ever seen Johnny with a phone.

JUDY: No he doesn't have it normally, he puts it in the drawer in the hallway.

JOHNNY: Yes yes, yes great. How's yours?

JUDY: We didn't really want him to have one at all, but the way that business works, he can't really do his job without it.

JOHNNY: Right yeah. Oh, OK, that's very

JUDY hands MARCUS his cake.

JUDY: He's got this new boss, I think she might be a workaholic. Fran?

JOHNNY: Yes, we've been wondering when the news might land.

FRAN: Just a little bit, yeah.

JUDY: Had her over for drinks the other night. Never off her phone.

JUDY hands cake to FRAN. MARCUS tucks into his.

JOHNNY: No, obviously you've got to take your time, make sure everyone feels they've had a fair crack.

Right. Yes.

Toby, right. Toby.

MARCUS: Oh my god that is *incredible.*

JOHNNY: Yes no of course. The numbers don't lie, do they?

MARCUS: I mean that is like, *wow.*

JOHNNY: Yes yes, great qualities. Leadership

MARCUS: Don't you think?

JOHNNY: Oh no, I wasn't expecting

FRAN: It's very nice.

JOHNNY: If there are things I can do to, um, improve

No sure yeah, you've got other people to call, we can talk about it on

Yes yes, no I appreciate it.

Alright yeah, thanks bye.

Yes you too, yeah bye.

JOHNNY hangs up.

MARCUS: You know, this might be the best chocolate cake I've ever had. Johnny's a lucky man.

JOHNNY sits on the bed. He looks around the room.

FRAN: Have you guys got a holiday planned?

JUDY: No, um. Jivestock was going to be

FRAN: Oh god I'm so sorry.

JOHNNY comes down the stairs.

You can borrow the Airstream anytime – go off for a week if you like.

JOHNNY comes in.

JUDY: Everything alright?

JOHNNY: Yes, just. Just work stuff.

JUDY: Cake?

JOHNNY: I'm alright, thanks.

MARCUS: You know you have to take a firm line with these people if you don't want them ringing you at the weekend. Set your boundaries. I have to be very clear with everyone at the agency.

JOHNNY: Right.

MARCUS: They respect it, in the main, don't they?

FRAN: Yes.

JUDY: Johnny doesn't normally answer it on a Sunday but he's got a promotion coming up.

MARCUS: Ah, best behaviour.

JOHNNY: So Cuba.

MARCUS: Yes, very exciting. Wonder how much it's changed now Castro's gone.

JOHNNY: Yes, crazy times.

JUDY: Where's Castro gone?

JOHNNY: Castro, Fidel Castro.

JUDY: Yes I know who Castro is.

JOHNNY: He died. Last year.

MARCUS: Longer than that, I think. Year before.

JOHNNY: Was it? I'd have said last year.

MARCUS: Let's look it up…

MARCUS googles it on his phone. JUDY watches.

JUDY: Completely missed that.

FRAN: You're so funny, how did you miss it?

MARCUS: Yes, there we go. Eighteen months ago.

MARCUS shows the phone to JOHNNY.

JOHNNY: Yup, OK.

MARCUS: So you're being promoted?

JOHNNY: Well not actually, no.

JUDY: What?

JOHNNY: There's a reshuffle going on but. I'm going to be pretty much staying where I am.

JUDY: There's not going to be an Assistant Manager?

JOHNNY: No, there's going to be an Assistant Manager, it's just not going to be me.

That's what Alex was ringing to tell me.

Letting me know before going into the office, so that's kind of her.

JUDY: Who's

JOHNNY: Toby.

JUDY: Toby? You've been there years longer than Toby.

JOHNNY: As I keep trying to explain it's not about length of service, it's not the army.

JUDY: After all the effort we went to, having her over for cocktails.

JOHNNY: Yeah, I'm not sure it helped.

JUDY: We didn't do anything except be welcoming.

JOHNNY: Yes, when does 'welcoming' tip over into 'scary'?

FRAN: I think maybe we should go, leave you guys to

JUDY: No no no don't go don't go. Why don't we all have a little drink, let's put a record on. It's nearly six o'

Five o'clock that's fine on a Sunday, isn't it?

JUDY goes over to the record player and puts on a jive.

MARCUS: Sorry to hear it, mate.

JOHNNY: S'alright. We'll get through it.

JUDY: Oh, I love this one, don't you?

JUDY goes to JOHNNY, tries to pull him into dancing with her.

Come on, let's have a little dance. Everything feels better after a dance.

JOHNNY: I'm not in the mood.

FRAN: I really think maybe we should go.

JUDY: Marcus, you'll dance, won't you? Entertain the troops?

FRAN: I was saying we should go.

JUDY: Come on, lend me your husband for a minute. Since we won't be having a dance at Jivestock. Just a little dance, cheer Johnny up.

FRAN stands back. MARCUS and JUDY take the floor (what there is of it), and begin to jive together. They're good.

JUDY: Johnny loves watching me dance, don't you, darling?

JOHNNY and FRAN watch JUDY and MARCUS dancing together.

The dance speeds up, with JUDY spinning faster and faster, her skirt flaring wider with each spin, until without noticing it she knocks over a cup of tea next to FRAN.

FRAN: Oh!

JOHNNY: Oh god, are you

FRAN: No it's fine it's fine.

JOHNNY: It's all over your dress – hang on, I'll get a cloth.

JOHNNY goes to the kitchen. JUDY and MARCUS continue to dance, oblivious.

JOHNNY goes into the cupboard under the sink. He rummages, then stops, looks more closely. He reaches into the back of the cupboard and pulls out a small pile of letters. He looks at the letter on the top, turns it over and opens it, then reads it.

JUDY: See, we don't need money to have fun, do we?

JUDY looks around for a response.

Where's Johnny?

FRAN: In there. My tea got knocked, he's gone for a cloth.

JUDY dashes to the kitchen.

MARCUS: What've you done?

FRAN: My drink got knocked, it's not my fault.

JUDY sees JOHNNY reading the letter.

JOHNNY: What's this?

JUDY: I can sort it, it's fine, I can sort it.

JOHNNY: This is a letter from the bank saying our mortgage didn't go out this month.

JUDY: It's fine, let's talk about it after they've

JOHNNY: Insufficient funds?

JUDY: I forgot to move some money across.

JOHNNY: Across from what?

JUDY: My account.

JOHNNY: This is our joint account.

JUDY: My savings account.

I move things around, Johnny, it's about interest rates and

You want me to explain it? You always say you don't really want to know, you just want me to do it.

JOHNNY: This says they're going to repossess our house.

JUDY: It doesn't.

JOHNNY: *(Reading.)* 'Please contact us immediately on the above number to arrange payment of the defaulted amount'.

JUDY: Which I

JOHNNY: '...failure to comply with this request, or if you miss further payments on your mortgage, we will have no alternative but to begin proceedings to repossess your home.'

Repossess our home?

JUDY: Don't panic, you're panicking.

JOHNNY: Of course I'm panicking, this is huge and I find it stuffed behind a tin of Brasso at the back of the

JUDY: Because I knew you'd panic, you panic.

JOHNNY: How, the fuck, Judy?

JUDY: Don't get angry at me

JOHNNY: Is this why you were so keen on me getting a promotion?

JUDY: I can get a credit card, put it on that, it'll be fine.

JOHNNY: You can't put a mortgage on a credit card, Jesus.

We've got to stop this.

JUDY: I'll find the money, I'll sort it out.

JOHNNY: I mean this, the fifties. This life.

MARCUS: Everything alright you two?

JUDY: Yes fine, sorry. Didn't mean to leave you on the dancefloor.

JOHNNY: Judy

JUDY: We've got guests.

JUDY goes back into the living room. A new track is playing on the record.

Oh this is a good one, this is a great one.

JUDY pulls MARCUS into the middle of the room and they dance. JOHNNY stays in the kitchen for a moment, then comes back into the living room. He goes over to the turntable and rips the needle off the record. Silence.

JOHNNY: I mean it, Judy. We've got to stop.

Blackout.

Interval.